



BEHIND THE LENS
(From left clockwise) Peter Pereira, Govind Nihalani, a poster for *Chhayaankan*, Baba Azmi and Nadeem Khan

vedi and editor Suchitra Sathe worked on it for over 11 weeks in Pune.

Chaturvedi mentions how he intends to release the interviews as a series of YouTube episodes. "I left out all technical aspects for those not familiar with film-making. Instead, we focused on humaneness, dignity, commitment, passion and hard work," he says. About plans to release the film for a wider audience, Chaturvedi recounts a line Naseeruddin Shah once said to him: "*Picture nahin chalti hai, bhidu! Sirf kismet chalti hai.*" ■

–Tatsam Mukherjee

RADIO

Right Frequencies

Several projects are now exploring how the radio made the world a smaller, better place

When radio became popular around the world in the late 1920s, one of its chief uses was to disseminate state propaganda. No one could have imagined that this very tool would become an accessory in thawing cultural differences, and lead to interesting exchanges of perspective. At the peak of the Cold War, for instance, a generation growing up in Madhepura (Bihar) was glued to the transistor. Radio Berlin International (RBI)—the foreign broadcasting station of the German Democratic Republic (GDR) or East Germany—was the source of news for many listeners' clubs in Bihar, including the Lenin Club in Madhepura chaired by Arvind Srivastava. In 1990, after the reunification of Germany, the club and RBI both, sadly, withered away.

Going through RBI's archives, Berlin-based academic Anandita Bajpai discovered the correspondence between the radio station and the listeners' clubs. She was struck by its intimacy, the unlikely friendship. Eventually, Bajpai managed to locate Srivastava. "I googled him, knowing that he was a poet and a part of the Bihar Progressive Writers' Association," Bajpai recounts during a video chat. In Madhepura, Bajpai discovered in the attic of the Lenin Club, RBI paraphernalia and, with it, a forgotten exchange between two radically different cultures. This became one of the core chaptrers in her recent book, *Cordial Cold War*, and a documentary, *The Sound of Friendship: Warm Wavelengths in a Cold, Cold War*.

There are today more projects like Bajpai's that are all trying to examine how sound has played an essential role in building intimacy between cultures. Historian Isabel Huacuja Alonso is working on a book called *Radio for the Millions* that looks at radio broadcasting in Hindi and Urdu between the years 1920 and 1980. Former radio journalist Syma Tariq, who is currently pursuing her PhD at CRiSAP (University of Arts, London), has also collaborated with Colomboscope (colomboscope.lk) on a six-part radio series, *A Thousand Channels*. This features talks, music, poetry from places such as Assam and Bangladesh, and even Australia. ■

–Tatsam Mukherjee



BAJPAI WAS STRUCK BY THE INTIMACY IN THE CORRESPONDENCE BETWEEN THE EAST BERLIN RADIO STATION AND THE LISTENERS' CLUBS



FRANZISKA KRUG/GETTY IMAGES

autobiographical purposes and evidence of post-colonial legacies. Filmmaker and curator Madhushree Dutta termed the archive "an assertion of reversed lens—a sharp opposite of colonial anthropology".

Born in 1945, Sundaram grew up in New Delhi. In 1963, when she began moderating the 'Asian Miniature series' for ARD television, she didn't speak a word of German. She weaponised her unfamiliarity with the language by memorising the script in front of her without really knowing what the words meant. It started off a remarkable career in German public television which lasted until 2004. In the course of her career, Sundaram has emerged as a distinct post-colonial voice from the global South.

Structured to resemble a media library, *The Fifth Wall* is curated from Sundaram's personal archive and that of German public broadcaster ARD. Centring Sundaram, the archive is an exhaustive record of the personal and political: a considered reflection on the various ways issues of internationalism, class, racism, alienation, migration and decolonisation can seep into the history of media. In her encapsulation of German history, Sundaram assumes the journalistic position of offering what she describes as "inside views of an outsider or outside views of an insider", depending on how one views it. ■

–Poulomi Das